

FREE SAMPLE

Rabbit Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 50-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Breeds, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 50 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 45 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/rabbit/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free rabbit care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/rabbit/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice: degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C), inches (in) and feet (ft) with centimeters (cm) or meters (m), square feet (sq ft) with square meters (m²), and pounds (lb) with kilograms (kg). The weight log is kept in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Food is measured in cups and tablespoons (tbsp), water in milliliters (mL), and prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 11 in order before buying anything, and the arrival and spay pages (21 and 22) before you bring a rabbit home. Two decisions cost the most to reverse: how much space the rabbit gets, and whether it is spayed or neutered. Get both right first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 35.

If your rabbit is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist on page 33. If hay is not unlimited and the bulk of the diet, fix that this week: it is the most protective habit available to you. If your rabbit is off its food right now, do not read further. Go to page 27, then call a vet today.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 33: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 42: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 34: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 38: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 44: Care, Vet & Bonding Log |
| ☐ Page 39: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 45: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Rabbits are sold as a starter pet and kept like a hamster, and almost everything that goes wrong follows from that one mistake. They are not a cage animal, and they are not a cheap animal once the vet is counted. This package reflects current welfare standards and peer-reviewed research, cross-checked against the sources on page 48.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A rabbit-savvy exotic vet. This matters more for rabbits than for most pets: rabbit physiology, anesthetic protocols and drug tolerances differ enough from a dog's or cat's that a general small-animal clinic can miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 07. Find one before you need one, ideally through a local rabbit rescue.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> , the European rabbit, ancestor of more than 300 breeds
Adult size	Highly variable by breed: about 2.5 lb (1.1 kg) for the smallest to more than 20 lb (9 kg) for giants
Lifespan	8 to 12 years indoors, and some reach 14 or even 16. Outdoor rabbits average 3 to 5 years
Native range	The Iberian Peninsula (Spain and Portugal), spread across Europe by the Romans and now found worldwide
Diet type	Hindgut-fermenting herbivore: it digests fiber in the cecum, a fermentation chamber after the small intestine. Grass hay is 80 to 85% of the diet, unlimited (page 13)
Space minimum	8 sq ft (0.75 m ²) enclosure plus 24 sq ft (2.2 m ²) exercise space, 5 or more hours a day
The one hard rule	No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours is a same-day vet call, not a wait-and-see (page 27)
Housing	Indoors. A neutered, bonded pair beats a single rabbit (page 20)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate. The spine is fragile, so support is not optional (page 17)
Conservation status	Endangered in the wild on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) list of threatened species, though it is invasive where it has been introduced

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$250 to \$545 for the setup, every item priced, plus \$150 to \$500 or more for a spay or neuter, and \$25 to \$100 for an adoption fee that often includes the surgery. Every line is on page 35.

Every year after

\$900 to \$1,895: food and litter at \$60 to \$135 a month, two wellness exams, and the yearly vaccine booster. The first year runs \$1,320 to \$3,045, without the adoption fee.

THE NUMBER THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OUT

A GI stasis workup alone can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits need an exotic vet whose rates are higher than a general clinic's. Keep \$500 to \$1,000 set aside separately from the routine budget. Rabbits hide illness well, and when something goes wrong it goes wrong quickly.

Fun facts worth knowing

- They eat some of their droppings on purpose. Cecotropes are soft pellets eaten straight from the source, carrying B vitamins the gut bacteria made on the first pass. A rabbit that stops eating them is telling you something (page 32).
- Their teeth never stop growing, about 1 cm (0.4 in) a month, as much as 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year. Hay is not a bedding material with a nutritional bonus, it is the dental equipment.
- Rabbit milk is so rich that a mother nurses once, rarely twice, a day for 2 to 10 minutes. Kits (baby rabbits) go roughly a day between feeds, so a nest left alone is usually normal, not abandoned.

The species, breeds, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, more than 300 breeds

Every pet rabbit, from a dwarf to a giant, is the same species: *Oryctolagus cuniculus*, the European rabbit. In the wild it lives in large underground warrens with strict social hierarchies, on grassland, meadow, farmland and forest edge, eating grasses, herbs, root vegetables and bark. It is a social animal that digs, which is why a single rabbit in a hutch is a compromise and why the digging in your living room is not misbehavior.

THE MONK AND THE LENT MYTH

The old story says rabbits were domesticated at a stroke around the year 600, when a pope ruled that newborn rabbits counted as fish and could be eaten in Lent. A graduate student sent to find the decree found that none exists. The story traces to a passage written in the year 584 about a man who ate young rabbits during Lent. Irving-Pease and Larson published the correction in 2018: domestication was a long process with no single starting point.

Size, breed and what changes in the care

SIZE	ADULT WEIGHT	SEXUALLY MATURE	NOTES
Small breeds, such as the Polish Dwarf and Dutch	from about 2.5 lb (1.1 kg)	3.5 to 4 months	More delicate, and needs especially careful handling
Medium breeds	about 7 to 12 lb (3.2 to 5.4 kg)	4 to 4.5 months	The size the standard space figures are written for
Giant breeds, such as the Flemish Giant	15 to 20 lb (6.8 to 9 kg), 2.5 to 4 ft (0.8 to 1.2 m) long	6 to 9 months	About 30 sq ft (2.8 m²) of base enclosure, more food, and a close eye on weight (pages 6, 14)

COAT OR FACE	WHAT IT CHANGES
Long-haired, angora	Brushing daily all year, and a higher flystrike risk (pages 23, 29)
Rex, and giants	More prone to sore hocks: Rex have less fur protecting the feet, and giants carry more weight on them. Soft, dry flooring and weight checks matter most
Lops, dwarf and mini breeds with short, flat faces	More likely to have dental problems, so the weekly mouth check matters most (page 28)

Larger rabbits are often calmer and sturdier. Temperament matters more than size or breed, in the pet and in a companion for it.

Lifespan

A rabbit kept indoors typically lives 8 to 12 years, and some reach 14 or even 16. Outdoor rabbits average 3 to 5, because of predators, weather and problems that go unnoticed without close daily contact. A wild rabbit lives 1 to 2 years. Plan for the whole span: a rabbit bought on impulse can outlast a lease, a school year and a dorm room.